

Name: The Mahabharata

Author: J.A.B. van Buitenen

Publication Year: The first volume, covering the Adi Parva (The Book of the Beginning), was published in 1973.

Publication: Published in multiple volumes by The University of Chicago Press.

Genre: Epic Literature

1. About the Author

J.A.B. van Buitenen was a renowned Indologist and Sanskrit scholar known for his deep understanding of ancient Indian texts. He was a professor at the University of Chicago and dedicated his career to translating and interpreting India's classical literature. His work on The Mahabharata is widely respected for its accuracy and clarity, offering Western readers an accessible way to engage with this monumental epic.

2. About the Book

The Mahabharata, translated and edited by van Buitenen, provides a concise yet comprehensive introduction to the world's longest epic. This version begins with the Adi Parva (The Book of the Beginning), introducing the dynastic conflict between the Kauravas and Pandavas that leads to the great war of Kurukshetra. The translation balances the epic's dramatic storytelling with its philosophical and moral reflections. Van Buitenen's detailed notes and explanations enhance the reader's understanding of the cultural and historical context, making the text both engaging and educational.

3. Recommendation

This book is highly recommended for readers who are new to The Mahabharata or want a clear and thoughtful introduction to Indian mythology. It is suitable for both casual readers interested in mythology and academics exploring the philosophical and cultural depth of ancient India. However, due to its length and complexity, readers should approach it with patience and an open mind.

4. Rating

Rating: ★★★★★

Van Buitenen's translation is a masterful effort, making a dense and complex text accessible. While it simplifies the epic for modern readers, some philosophical sections may still be challenging for newcomers.